flavors was served, a feast that could have fed an entire company of soldiers for a few days—or, indeed, one thousand and one nights.

Following an exchange of presents and farewells, we returned to our waiting plane. In the air, the prime minister summed up the visit by saying that an Israeli foot on the ground in the Persian Gulf was important and necessary.

One last story: Rabin believed in the paradigm that power creates deterrence and deterrence enables increased flexibility and room to maneuver in diplomatic negotiations. Israel's relations with Germany, since the early years of the state, have been unique. During Shamir and Rabin's terms, Bernd Schmidbauer, the minister in charge of coordinating the intelligence and security services in Chancellor Kohl's government, served as the link for all matters that needed to be dealt with discreetly.

We were flying to Germany on a small business jet. We took off, in secret, from Ben Gurion airport in the afternoon and landed at the airport in Cologne. We set off in a convoy to the chancellor's private residence in Bad Godesberg, one of the towns surrounding Bonn, which still served as the capital, although the process of transferring official institutions to Berlin was already in full swing. The chancellor was a mountain of a man, and his presence overshadowed everyone else. We were seated around an intimate dining table and were served a modest dinner. The main topic discussed at the meeting was German aid to Israel in the form of submarines, but the two leaders also took advantage of the meeting to exchange views on the state of the world and Rabin's efforts to advance the peace process. Approximately two hours later we were already on our way back to the plane. I summed up the trip by saying that while a business jet does not come cheap, the deal Rabin had "closed" with the chancellor justified the cost of the flight.

And a few words in closing: this man, who felt at home in the courtyards of kings, presidents, and heads of state, took as a given his participation in exercises for special operations in target countries; even after a long and exhausting day of work, he could spend an entire night in the middle of the Negev or the Golan Heights with combat soldiers, talking to them and asking them questions, checking everything to the very last detail, and giving his comments before disappearing. He was also known to insist on observing the exercises of operational squads at various hours of the day on the noisy city streets and to marvel that the people in the area